

The Mahāsi Technique and What We Need to Understand to Practice Vipassanā

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 46:43

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This evening, I just want to go over the technique a little bit that we're actually practicing, especially for those for whom it's quite new or completely new. And then to look at what the Buddha means by right awareness. And a quick look at the hindrances, what stops us to get this right awareness. And then finally the three characteristics — what is it we're supposed to be investigating after all.

A technique, remember, is to try to get us into a certain place. The technique itself doesn't produce anything. It's not the technique that allows insights to come. The insights, whatever they come, is always achieved by the intuitive intelligence that is the active part of awareness.

Awareness has two sides. It has a receptive side of awareness, what we would in English call awareness, and an active side of grasping the situation in its fullness. This intuitive awareness is working for us all the time. Every time in ordinary daily life, you have a sudden brainwave or you hear a scratch and then you think, what could that be? And then you realize, oh, that's the cat. All that is part and parcel of this intuitive intelligence. And it's not to be confused with the intellect. It uses the intellect. The intellect itself is not intelligence.

I just want to get first of all into the actual technique. The intellect, which is a collection of these concepts and ideas that we have — views, opinions and so on — is always a product of our history. It's always a way in which we can remember things. So even at the simplest level of an orange, you must have had lots of experiences with oranges and you have this concept of an orange.

Somehow we have to release this awareness from its confusion with the intellect especially. It's our biggest enemy, thinking. So this technique is actually drawing the intellect down to a single, simple, concrete word. So you're not thinking about anything. The intellect is there, as it were, pushing you towards the object. So if you've got pain in the knee, for instance, a bit of discomfort in the knees, the word pain might come to mind to describe what you're experiencing, or aching. And you just keep repeating that: pain, pain, ache, ache. But your attention is not on the word. It's not on the concept. It's on the actual sensations.

When some people use this technique, they find the word is so strong, so obvious in front of them, they can't seem to feel anything, or they barely feel something because the word is so strong. What that is mirroring back to the meditator is that this confusion of awareness with intellect is very strong. Somehow you've got to keep looking through the word, over the word, behind the word. You've got to keep pointing the attention to what it is you're actually experiencing. And what that does is it draws us down beyond the intellect with all its opinions and concepts and all that to direct experience, which is, of course, the sensations to do with pain, sensations in the knee.

So the word has to approximate what you're actually experiencing. It's no good saying, if you've got a pain in the knee, banana, banana. That's not going to really help you focus in on the pain. It's got to be something which is relevant to what you're experiencing, and it must be done at a rate which is keeping the intellect occupied, or else it'll shoot off on: maybe I should move, maybe I shouldn't move, should I move now? Maybe it just goes on and on and on. So you've got to close that down with this very simple word. So whatever you're doing, if you can find a word and then draw your attention to what you're actually experiencing, then that, of course, is releasing this awareness from its delusion of thinking that it is the intellect. And that's the same with imagination. The imagination and intellect work together. There's always an image comes with a concept, unless the concept is entirely abstract, like liberty.

The danger is of course that it becomes a sort of mantra — it's just working in the background and it's losing that ability to point the awareness. The Mahasi himself talked about throwing a stone at bottles on a wall. So your eye is on the bottle, right? Not on the stone. It's not on your hand, is it? It's actually on the bottle, you see, and you're throwing and what the stone is doing, or what your intention of hitting that bottle is, it's putting your attention directly on the bottle. So it's the same with this. You've got this ache in the knee and your attention wants to be right there with the ache.

You have to use the word to get closer to what it is you're experiencing. The technique itself is to get us beyond the technique. So it's drawing us to a concentration whereby we are just aware of the sensation of actually what's happening. So if you think about it, if I have an ache in my knee and I say pain, there's two consciousnesses there. There's one where I'm receiving this information about pain, and the second one is actually giving it a name. So there's restlessness in the mind. So by constantly making that effort to drive the attention towards the pain, time begins to collapse. And there'll come a point of what we might call absorption, where there's no time to note because you're completely absorbed into feeling the sensation of pain. That's what it's leading us towards.

That doesn't come easy, right? You can't sit down and just get that. You have to keep working at it very slowly, very patiently. And it might only come in a little blip or a little blob before you're out of it again. But at least it manifests to the meditator that there is a level of concentration, a level of focus where you are completely involved in the object. And at that point, of course, the sense of self will disappear because self is also a reflection, and with it a sense of time. Time and self always arise together. So those moments of just being the knowing of what you're actually experiencing are precious little moments.

This intuitive awareness is very clear. It's not being fogged over by emotions or by images or by intellect. And that's when little insights come. Of course, there are occasionally a person might have a big insight. But generally speaking, they're small little insights which accumulate over time and change our attitude to things. So the real message there is to really, really put effort into that noting, you see. If you slacken on the noting, the noting becomes a mantra. See, rising, falling, rising, falling. And then you're off to Costa del Sol. And then when you come back, you can hear yourself saying, rising, falling. So you've taught yourself to say rising and falling, which is absolutely useless. So it's going to be something really direct and pointed.

The other thing is you get bored. So you have to be careful of boredom. So if you get bored, that's your object of meditation, right? That's when you say, oh, this is boredom. That's interesting. And you move towards it and you feel it. And your noting word is boredom, boredom, right? So it is this constant effort, see. And if you find yourself getting tight, so just relax — you can open the eyes, just relax a bit and come back to the practice. If you find yourself getting a bit lazy about it, then, you know, talk to yourself. Stop this immediately. Let's get back to the practice. Don't let yourself off. So that's the noting, right? And it is, in a way, specific to the Mahasi technique, although I did hear of a Zen teacher, Maezumi Roshi, who used to work in America, used to use noting.

The fact is, of course, that this labeling, this noting is going on anyway. That's the point. Even if you're not aware of it, as soon as you experience something, you're putting a label on it.

The next thing is going slow. Well, that's pretty straightforward. It's just the slower you go, the more you see. It's as simple as that. And by slowing things down, you begin to see minute movements, minute movements. There's a lovely incident in one of the commentaries called the *Visuddhimagga*, the path of purification, which is a sort of medieval text. And it's a great spiritual manual, but you wouldn't want to read it from page one to 1,500 — you're driving potty. But it is a great encyclopedia. You just open it, and it'll tell you something.

It talks about this particular teacher who was giving a talk, and he suddenly raised his hand and stopped, and then put his hand back down. And all the students said, what happened there? What happened? He said, I didn't note the intention to raise the hand. So that's how fine it can get. And if you think of how many automatic movements we make, which are perfectly ethical — opening a door, closing a door, switching a light on, switching it off — and we don't see that every action we make, whether it's a thought pattern, a pattern of speech or an action, always begins with an intention. And that's so important because that's the only choice we have. Once you're committed, that's it, you're done for.

So it's a case of catching the intention. And when you can see the intention, the desire to do something, that's your moment of choice. Will I do it? Will I not do it? That's the only bit of little bit of freedom that we have, you might say. So going slow really helps us to see this, the role of intention and, with it coupled with it, of course, the role of action. That once you empower it, you've done something. So that's why the Buddha says action — the will is action. You can't separate the will from the action. It's a bit like, you

know, if you throw a stone into the air, you can't separate the force from the stone. You can't take it: well, this is the force and this is the stone. They're both completely at one with each other. So it's the same with an action and a will.

I think you'll find that if you get the habit of stopping — and this also in daily life, you know, to stop after you've done something, after a phone call or anything — you do get more of a sense of presence, you know, that you've been here most of the day, that you've been here most of the time. It really does keep bringing you back into the present moment.

So this going slow, that's the third part: this noting intentions, and to understand *kamma* meaning action and of course the product — you know, to be aware that whenever we do something there's always going to be a product from it, there's always going to be a consequence, right? So those are the three things that we say mark out the Mahasi technique as such: noting, going slow, and noting intentions.

So I'll remind you of that, hopefully, if I remember, at the end of the talk.

The next task, of course, is to understand what the Buddha means by this right awareness. A bank robber has awareness. Somebody who's fraudulent has awareness. Awareness is with us virtually all the time. Even in sleep, there's a sense of awareness. I mean, otherwise you wouldn't hear the alarm clock. It's there in a residual sense. So when the Buddha talks about right awareness, he's talking about something quite specific.

It has two qualities. It has the quality of coming from a place of not knowing. In other words, not knowing, not coming from a place of I know, I'm sure. As soon as you do that, then whatever you experience will only be something that you agree with, only something that you've already imagined. So this would be a classic terrible mistake about, say, *Nibbāna*. So if you have an idea of *Nibbāna*, then if you attain it, you'll be definitely deluded because it's not imaginable. It's gone beyond imagination. The awareness has to be clear, you see, and it has to be — when it becomes clear, it becomes original, right? And this is why in Zen they talk about original mind. What they mean is original awareness.

The example I use is of a little child. So everybody's seen a three-year-old, especially, you know, round about that age — three, four, five — and they see for the first time something like a spider. And you can see their eyes glue on it — you know, they just stick on it and the world disappears. And the other thing that happens is the jaw drops and they look gauntless, you know. And our job as adults is to wake them up, which is a terrible thing actually. And so there they are glued onto this spider, and then after they've received enough information they always turn around to mummy or daddy and say, what is it? You see, then they get this label: spider.

Now, the next time they see a spider, they rejoice. They say, spider, spider. And mummy and daddy say, very good. See? But the problem is, they haven't seen this other spider. What they've seen is a concept of the idea of a spider, which they're already plunking on to this new spider. In other words, they've lost the

original mind. They've lost that original way of receiving information before concepts get in the way.

So our job is to get back to that point where there are no more concepts or ideas coming in to distort the way we are looking at things. That doesn't mean to say that you lose the concept. It's always there. In fact, it's rather useful in daily life. But in Vipassana, it's a bit of a pain.

If we have that concept of a child, with the glued eyes and the jaw relaxed — the reason the jaw is relaxed is because there's no thinking. In your meditation, you might find that when you're thinking, you might just catch these little movements on your tongue caused by the thinking pattern. So when the jaw is relaxed and the tongue is relaxed and the eyes are fixed, you see, when you take that inwardly into yourself and you're just observing, just feeling, just experiencing, then we're getting to original mind, or better, in my language, pure awareness. Intuitive awareness, remember. IA, not AI — there's nothing artificial about it. This is the real thing.

That's this intuitive awareness, and this really comes about through the story of the Buddha, which many of you will already know. But remember that when he left home he was in a bit of a crisis — he was in what we would call an existential crisis. I mean it's put down as, you know, these five messengers where he sees somebody very, very sick, very old, a corpse, and somebody sitting under a tree suggesting that there might be a way out of this sickness, aging and death.

His first two teachers teach him how to attain beautiful mental states, and these you find in all religions — that's devotional religions especially — through repetitive prayer, mantra, even music, repetitive music. And of course, when he comes out of those absorptions, well, he's back to being anxious and depressed again. So it didn't really work.

The next thing he tried was, of course, this very severe asceticism, which it's suggested he was following the Nigantha, the leader of the Jains, the Jain leader. And in Jainism, the understanding is that the body is the expression of your bad karma. And if you can get rid of the body, the soul would rise naturally to heaven. So the Jain reduces their body, and it's considered to be a saintly thing to slowly starve oneself to death. And many elderly people in Jainism actually will do that, letting go of the body. And I would have thought that if that's done properly, that's quite a spiritual journey, letting go of the body.

But he said he got so thin that he could hold his spine through his stomach. So if you try that, you'll see how thin he was. And he said it was just more suffering. So when he comes out from that, you can imagine that he's quite despairing. I mean, he's now been to all the teachers, he's been to all the discussions, and he's stuck. He doesn't see a way out. And that's when he is sitting by the road and a woman comes who's called Sujata. I think it was a name given to her later on. It just means a happy birth, an auspicious birth. And offers him some sweetmeats that she was going to offer to a local shrine. And I think that at that point he remembers this childhood memory of watching his father doing a ploughing ceremony.

and he remembers himself being as absorbed in that watching as he is when he's in these absorption

states, but with something extra—with this sense of enquiry, like "what is my daddy doing?" And I think that turned his whole meditation round upon itself.

Instead of trying to escape unhappiness, escape sickness, disease and death, and trying to achieve happiness, trying to achieve something, he just turns round upon the actual suffering and inquires, "How does the suffering arise?" And it's in chasing that avenue of investigation—where is the kernel problem of suffering—that he finally awakens to the truth, or finally discovers the truth, which is, of course, this sense of identity. But we'll come to that in a minute.

So here we are now with an image of a child. The awareness is clarified of all conceptual thinking, and you're just inside yourself, you're using a noting word. It might be—you're just going back to this, to the old knees—so you might be using "pain, pain," and you're just feeling it. You're just feeling it, and you're going into the sensation.

Now at first it'll just be a pain or an ache. But as you go into it, as you'd enter into the pain, of course it begins to deconstruct. And the Buddha's big on deconstruction. And what you find is probably a lot of heat, a lot of pressure, a lot of movement, and your noting word changes. You're no longer saying "pain," you're saying "heat, movement, pressure." So at that point, you're right there at the sense base. You're right there where the information is coming from the body into the mind. And it's at that point that you can begin to see impermanence much more clearly because everything is really arising and passing away.

And then when you come out to the second position of perception, where you give it a label—"pain, pain"—that's the point where you decide whether it's pleasurable or unpleasurable. So you can see this movement. And as soon as it's perceived as unpleasurable, there will be the desire to escape. So you can see this process very clearly just by doing that.

And you can do it with emotions. If you feel very sad, your first word is "sadness, sadness." But when you go into the sadness, what is it that you actually experience? It's not sadness. It'll be some form of heat, some sort of movement, but it won't be sadness. And then when you come out again, it'll be sadness. Now it doesn't deny the fact of sadness, it just takes away that sense of solidity. And interestingly enough, with emotions, when you're down at that level of just perceiving them, just allowing them to manifest, they're actually curing themselves. They're actually expending that energy.

So the awareness—what we're trying to do is to keep on focusing in on whatever we experience, and the word, the label should help us to get there. And then at some points we'll find ourselves dropping into moments of just pure absorption. Difficult over a weekend, slightly possible over five days. Unfortunately, this stuff doesn't come easy.

So that's the awareness. Now, what clouds the awareness is the hindrances. And tomorrow Wei will give a talk, a much more detailed talk about the hindrances. But basically they split into two types. There's the type which sends the mind all over the place and the type where you disappear, which is dullness,

lethargy and all that sort of stuff. So it's always in a sense the same technique. As soon as you are aware of how you're reacting to something and how you are indulging what is pleasant or trying to push something away which is unpleasant, then you allow that to manifest in your mind. You put your attention there. And when it disappears, you're left with the original hindrance, so-called. But when it's like that, it becomes your teaching tool because now you can investigate it. But as soon as you give in to a desire of not wanting to feel the unpleasant or wanting to indulge the pleasant, then, of course, you're actually creating, recreating the same old problems.

So, these hindrances—as soon as you feel something, so for instance you might be planning. Everybody's planning to get a holiday in at some point, so you might be planning this amazing holiday. And when you come off that planning, come off it, and you come into the body, and what you're feeling is the agitation of planning, the excitement of it in the body. And the idea is to actually sink into that and allow it to manifest and that hindrance of wanting to escape the present moment and find ourselves in a beautiful place is slowly exhausting itself.

Now, when it's something which is slightly more unpleasant, so we have some anxiety, some worry in our lives, and it becomes a sort of an obsessive thing in the mind. So just be very patient. Just keep bringing yourself back, keep bringing yourself back to the body and feel the worry. And often if it's a worry that you can't do anything about anyway because you're on retreat, it's often a little trick to actually write it on a piece of paper, things to do when the retreat is over. And that often undermines its urgency. Because if it is of course of immediate urgency, then you need to deal with it.

So again, it's a case of recognizing the emotional, the mental state, the mood, and just come off that thinking business and come into the body and just feel it. And then to be aware of your reaction. So often you'll find yourself with two states to look at: the original thing coming up, the pain, the emotional agitation, whatever it is, and this reaction. So you always stay there, you always keep your eye on this reaction, and you wait for that to completely pass away. If not, it remains there as an energy. And you only have to have a moment of inattentiveness and you're off. That's it, you're gone. And then you have to pull yourself back from the moon and come back into the body and start all over again.

So it's a case of keeping that awareness very sharp, both aware of the original information that's coming in—the emotion, the mood, the pain, whatever—and your reaction. You just stay there dead still. You don't have to do anything—that's the wonderful thing, you don't have to actually do anything—because all this is just energy, it's just conditioning, that's all. And you're just allowing the conditioning to manifest. That's it. It's as simple as that.

So now when it comes to dullness and lethargy, whereas these other hindrances—everything we want, everything we desire, everything we don't like, all the doubts that sometimes assail us, the guilts, the shame, all that sort of stuff—they're all whirlwinds. They're all taking us up. But dullness and lethargy is a whirlpool. It's taking us down into oblivion. And the wonderful thing about oblivion is there's no suffering

there. But unfortunately, you always come out. So it's not a permanent place to be.

So when we get that dullness in the head, just remind yourself that you've got to stay awake. That's the big command that you have inside yourself. Stay awake, don't fall asleep. And if you get that heaviness in the body, and both—you're going to get both, unfortunately—then you stay with it. And one way to keep yourself awake is just keep moving around. Keep buzzing around the head, inside the head, and keep moving around the body. And that way you remain awake.

And look upon dullness and lethargy—so we're not talking about sleep here. We know we need sleep. We're talking about this overlay, which comes from laziness, from indulging in too much sleep sometimes, and often in using sleep as a way to escape something. When you're a bit depressed, you sort of just lay yourself out. I think somebody called it the duvet dive. So you just disappear for an hour or so. So it's a case of recognizing that it is an unwholesome conditioning. And in Buddhist terminology, it's just as serious as anxiety, depression, all the rest of it. It can suck the energy out of your life if it becomes quite bad.

So those are your working with the hindrances. So now we have to be clear about what it is we're trying to investigate. So we've already talked about this process of reaction. How we've taught ourselves to grasp hold of what's pleasant and to sort of maintain that grip and to try and develop something out of it, and when it's something unpleasant we've taught ourselves to run for it or to push it away—fight, flight. So our job now is to let go, is to allow those reactions to exhaust themselves and to be open to what's actually there now.

It's not a case of forcing the issue. You've got to be careful here that you're not fighting the mind or anything. As soon as you see the reaction, your attention goes to the reaction and you just sit back within yourself and just feel it. Just know it's there. Allow it to express itself. And then when it passes away, you're undermining a particular habit, a habit that is unwholesome for us.

And the Buddha points to this desire as being the direct cause of our suffering. It's a manifestation of delusion—seeking some form of real happiness in the sensual world, which can't deliver, if only because we die. That's a good enough reason for not being deluded.

The second one is impermanence. The mind is extremely good at stringing information into a line which gives us a sense of continuity, and this continuity allows us to believe in some sort of substantiality—that's something real there. And one of the things that we do in the meditation by closing in upon sensations and feelings is to see that they're made up of little bits. They're not only made up of different sensations—this concept, say, of pain, it's made up of different sensations—but they're always changing, they're always moving. Nothing's ever still, and they're never the same. They might seem the same, but they can't be the same because whatever has happened has gone, and now we've got another sensation.

So it's catching that movement, it's catching the fact that the mind is creating continuity for us. And the

delusion that comes with it is that sense of substance, that there must be something real there.

Now there's also, of course, on a greater level, the whole contemplation of sickness, especially—well, aging and death. I'm getting to know this very well. So aging is something that is going to happen if you live long enough. So that's just one of those things. And so even in your daily life, to bring the fact—every time you look in a mirror, you might catch the extra wrinkle. People tell me, when they see me on the screen, they say, "I look young." And I say, "Well, the camera is very kind, but the mirror is brutal, absolutely brutal." There's no escaping the mirror.

So it is a case of reminding ourselves. In the medieval worlds, they always had this *memento mori*, this reminding of death, so like a little skull on their desk and things like that. And the way to remind ourselves is that after every action, after every meal, at the end of a day, just to know that that is a mini death. Once you've finished a meal, that's it, it's gone. The most beautiful meal that you can have and then it's finished and that's it, it's gone. You're never going to have that meal again. You might have something similar but you'll never have that meal again. And it's really driving home that every moment there's a collapse, there's an ending, there's a completion.

Of course, while we're still human beings wandering around the place, we rise again. But there will come that day, inevitably, when we disappear completely from the world. So the contemplation of death, the Buddha says, is the most efficacious. It's the contemplation that leads to liberation, as a contemplation, because right there is the whole concept of self—that's where it's really totally undermined. So contemplating impermanence, transience, has its advantages. And interestingly enough, of course, the more you contemplate these things, the more you realize how precious life is.

I was just reading now in the newspaper about one of our rugby heroes—can't remember his name—and the poor man has motor neuron disease. And he's only about forty, two young kids, got about a couple of years to live. He was a great rugby player. And he talks about the sheer joy of living in the moment. And I think that's what happens when we find this real strength within ourselves when we actually have to face our death. And it was just so lovely to hear him talk in a way that you would expect every meditator to talk—like he knows he's got probably a year left, and he's talking about the sheer beauty of every moment and the wonder of it. So the contemplation of death is absolutely wonderful.

Now when we get to the identity, the sense of self, so here we have a deep problem. The sense of self that we experience is a consequence of a deeper delusion. The deeper delusion is a view of self. And we don't really know the view of self until something undermines the whole view of self, which is, of course, death itself. That's why contemplation of death is so powerful.

So this sense of self—the image I use is of Narcissus. So Narcissus, as you know, was this very beautiful young man and he looked into a pool and he saw his image. He fell in love with his own image, you might say, and he embraced it and drowned. Now, the Greek myth is normally said to be about self-pride. But in terms of the self, it works perfectly. Because water in mythology is normally to do with creation. So it's the

world of your mind. And the awareness comes into the mind. It does it every morning you wake up. It wakes up into the mind. And as it wakes up into the mind, it catches its own reflection in the mind. And that's the awareness becoming aware of itself.

And then of course it goes through that door of "this is me, this is me." It enters into the world of the mind and that's the world that we create—this little universe that we're in, constantly being created, recreated through all the information that's coming from the outside and then the information coming from the inside.

What we're doing is we're pulling ourselves out from that pond, we're pulling ourselves out of the mind and sitting back onto the bank and aware of this image of the self, aware of that self-image. But that still isn't attacking the real problem which lies in the awareness itself, in the way that it's looking. And that's the view of self—it's a delusion. And the problem with a delusion is you don't know you're deluded. So it's a big problem. And the only way we can deal with it is by keep being aware of the sense of self—the self-awareness.

So now I'm giving this talk and I'm aware of myself doing it. If I put a lot of attention towards me giving a talk, I'll lose my place in the talk, because my attention is going back into myself. So I'm aware of myself giving this talk, but that is just a reflection. It's not the delusion.

So when you fall asleep, you might think, "Well, where does that sense of self go?" Well, it disappears because the mind's gone to sleep. But the awareness is still there. It's not lost. The awareness isn't lost. If the awareness is lost, well, you're dead.

So now just think for a moment, if the doctor said to you, "If you fall asleep, you're dead." Now, would you fall asleep? We fall asleep because we're absolutely sure that tomorrow morning we'll wake up. If there was any doubt in your mind that you might not wake up, I'm pretty sure you'd be sticking pins in your eyes to keep awake. So that sense of self we can get rid of very simply.

And we get rid of it in ordinary daily life. We lose it when we watch a good video. You just absorb it into a video and you come out and you say, well, that was very good, wasn't it? That was great. So the sense of self can disappear, can come back, but not the delusion of self. That's much harder to get rid of and that's really what we're chasing—we're chasing this delusion that we have about what our real identity is. And it's done through this slow process of observation and feeling.

To give you another image that I work with: when we're born, it seems for four months thereabouts all we have is this shower of information. We're bombarded by all sorts of information which we can make no sense of whatsoever. But we do know one thing: we know when we are happy, we know when we're in a pleasant state, we know when we're not in a pleasant state. And that's when, of course, we give these shrieking cries and mother comes to comfort us.

Then round about four months, it seems, we create an object. So from all this, we start making sense. And

the first object is your carer, your mother, normally. And very slowly, this baby pushes this inner world of confusion out and creates an objective world. And even the sense of self begins to formulate as something separate from that world. So by the age of three, we do know that we are a boy or a girl or whatever, and we're very clear about, well, this is me and everything else is not me. So we've already concretised the sense of self around the body.

Now what we're doing in our meditation is we're sitting back within ourselves and we're pushing the whole of the mind and heart and sensations out into an objective world. That's all we're doing. So all the sensations that before, when we were completely deluded before we came to meditation, which we thought we were, we're now making into an object. And you're pushing out an emotion and you're saying there's an emotion. And you can see images in the mind and your thoughts—so everything you're pushing outwards. And what's pulling itself out to observe this is your very awareness.

And as it begins to release itself, clarify itself, as opposed to the body with its sensations and feelings, the heart with its moods and emotions, and the mind with its thoughts and images, as it clarifies itself as not that, it begins to experience its own true nature. And that nature is *Nibbāna*. That nature is one of unshackling from the imprisonment of the heart, body and mind. And that's the process of awakening. And that's what we're doing. Even if you don't believe me, that's what we're doing.

So to make this easier for us, we have various techniques. There's as many techniques as original teachers. I must have practised at least four or five in the Theravāda tradition. And then you have Zen, and they have their way of doing it, which I did a couple of years. And of course you have the Tibetans with Dzogchen and all that. Every culture, every form of Buddhism has some form of technique to help the meditator to begin to really investigate this so-called human being.

And so in the Mahāsi—himself developed this idea of really noting something to help the mind, to help that awareness clarify itself from thinking and to go slow so that we can really begin to see the tiniest of movements. And to note intention because that's so important when it comes to conditioning. When we talk about *kamma*, kamma in the normal sense of your comeuppance, it's always your conditioning. It's your conditioning that's causing either for you to be happy or unhappy.

So basically that's it. And I hope that you just give yourself to the practice.

Could I just say that tomorrow, the weekenders, the official ending is four o'clock. But you can carry on if you want. And even for the next few days that we have—Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday—you can always join us in the morning and evening. You don't have to completely disappear. But the official ending will be around about four o'clock.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused even greater confusion, and that you will, by your constant effort, be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

